



believe they are descended from **Haik**, great-grandson of the Biblical Noah, whose Ark came to rest on **Mount Ararat** in the Caucasus Mountains. Yerevan, Armenia's capital city, is one of the oldest continuously

inhabited places on Earth. Archeological evidence demonstrates that a city existed in this region as long as 5,000 years ago. Today, 1.25 million people live in Yerevan, and it is the focus of Armenian life.



CITY LIFE

Two-thirds of Armenians live in cities or towns, with half of them in Yerevan. This makes it a crowded city where space is limited. Many homes are in high-rise apartment blocks. Most of these are privately owned, not government owned.

LOVE OF DANCE

Armenia has a strong tradition of both folk dance and ballet. As part of the Soviet Union, the arts were heavily subsidized, but less money is available for music and dance today.



VARDAVAR

The whole of Armenia takes part in this water festival, held in the height of summer. Water is precious, but on this day it is thrown around generously. People believe that watering someone makes them pure—but most children just like an excuse for soaking adults!



There's nowhere to hide Vardava—even drivers keep their windows shut to avoid a drenching.

MOUNT ARARAT

In the past, this mountain was part of Armenia, but today it lies inside Turkey's borders. However, it is still a symbol of Armenian national identity and a religious site. Many Armenians live near Mount Ararat, and for those living far away, it represents their homeland.



VOSKI ASHUN

Every October in the town of Hrazdan, people from all over Armenia gather in traditional dress to celebrate the changing seasons in the festival of *Voski Ashun*, or "Golden Fall."

